UNION LIFE GROUP - Men and Marriage

June 26

1. **In your own mind, think of a challenge, trial, stronghold or hurtful** situation you are facing. Frustration, anger or bitterness; worry, fear, stress or anxiety; finances, money, vocation or career; disappointment(s); decision; depression, or suicide; responding to a difficult person/people; addictions (gambling, alcohol, drugs, sexual addictions); marriage and/or parenting or other relationships; health, death or dying.

2. **What are your emotions and actions? What do they tell you?**
   Examples of emotions: Discouraged, defeated, sad, hopeless, miserable, fearful, trapped, confused, unwanted, alone, humiliated.
   Example of actions: Did nothing, prayed, confronted someone, yelled, talked to friends/family/therapist, blamed, controlled the situation by…
   Important: Emotionally, we can live as God wants, in joy (James 1:3-12) and hopefulness (Romans 5:1-5). But how?
   Important: Behaviorally, we can do as God wants by loving our enemies (Matt 5:43-48). But how?

3. **Repent, which means changing your outlook.**
   How satisfied are you with how you feel? _____Your responses? _____
   Yes or no questions: Are you at peace with the situation? ____
   Important: Let your dissatisfaction drive you to seek wisdom, truth and a new approach. Don't let a good challenge go to waste.
   Ask: What does God and the Holy Spirit want to convey?

4. **Detect what's in your heart.** Eric's 4 idols that drive desires, wants, perceived needs, and expectations of yourself and others.
   Control is an illusion. It opposes trust in God. It says, "I know best" and I don't like this. I feel motivated to squish this and will control it.
   Power and Pleasure oppose humility and servanthood. When pride and self-seeking dominate, conflict, division, and isolation follows.
   Comfort and ease can lead to irritability, hopelessness, and addictions
   Approval exalts others as judge and God. You feel underappreciated

5. **Correct beliefs to what is true** (Phil 4:8). Follow your GPS
   Believe differently. See challenges as having meaning and a purpose. See the promise not the problem. This is not prosperity gospel or positive thinking, but biblical truth. How do you correct the beliefs? **Follow GPS**

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G- God

Guilt-free: Thank God for his mercy and grace. I live in guilt-free forgiveness.
Hope-filled: I live in confidence that my future is bright by faith in God.
Stress-free: My troubles are manageable by truly surrendering to God.
Freedom: I am free from traps that enslave me. I am not a slave to my desires.
Satisfied: God alone is sufficient to satisfy my life. Although I don't wish for trials and difficulties, they cause me to rely on God. He is enough.

P - Purpose:

Christ is my purpose. There are many areas to find substitutes for my purpose. They don't fulfill. My most important purpose is to embrace meaning and fulfillment in my relationships to God.
Pleasing God is my purpose. The approval of people pales by comparison to my desire to please God.
Confidence. My clear purpose is to live with a confident belief in where I came from and where I am going. I know my purpose. It is unwavering.
Wholeness and Holiness. My purpose is foremost to be holy, set apart and growing my faith in God. My purpose is not solely happiness, which is subject to circumstances.
Control over my life is God's purpose. My purpose is not to control, but to joyfully trust God even when I don't see the beautiful tapestry He is creating.
Love, help and serve others is my purpose. My purpose is not to do whatever I think is best for me, but to do what I know is right.

S - Self

Christ fulfills me. I have contentment, joy and peace in God alone.
My identity is in Christ. My identity is not in my failures or in the way others see me. I am a child of the King. He covers me with His righteousness.
My greatest need. My relationship with God is my greatest need. I want comfort, ease, security, importance, a good marriage and children and many other desires. Yet, they are not more important than my communion with God.
God meets my needs, not always my wants. I don't need to anxiously attempt to meet my unmet rights and desired needs. I am complete in Christ.
My lasting joy: My pursuit of lasting contentment and joy found in God, rather than temporary happiness, helps to solve my situation.
My relationship with God: My relationship with God can help me overcome my relational problems with others. It causes me to love others, rather than seek to be loved by them.
I am not all-knowing: I don't know what is best for me, but God does. He can better control or influence my circumstances and the people around me better than I can.
I am made better through criticism: Believing my identity in Christ enables me to listen and understand rather than defend my actions. Criticism makes me better if the criticism is true or stronger if I know it is false.